

# Pitching Research

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# Pitching Research

## Abstract

Building on Faff's (2015) pitching template, in the current paper I further explore a methodical approach to pitching a new research proposal. Emphasis is given to providing general advice to both "pitchers" and "pitchees". Moreover, the current paper provides an update on an extensive array of supplementary online resources. Most notably, to demonstrate that the pitch template is readily adaptable to many fields, a library of completed examples currently spans **THIRTY SEVEN** alternative research areas, namely: (1) corporate finance; (2) accounting; (3) corporate sustainability; (4) inter-disciplinary; (5) qualitative; (6) management; (7) chemistry; (8) mechanical engineering; (9) computer science; (10) mathematics; (11) physics; (12) healthcare; (13) psychology; (14) strategy; (15) governance; (16) sport; (17) energy policy; (18) climate change; (19) research policy; (20) taxation; (21) banking; (22) behavioural finance; (23) public policy and regulation; (24) education; (25) market microstructure; (26) information systems; (27) immunology; (28) biology; (29) management accounting; (30) multidisciplinary (climate science); (31) accounting theory; (32) accounting history; (33) archaeology; **(34) behavioural economics**; (35) humour; (36) phytology; (37) organic chemistry. Other online materials and support include: web portal; YouTube videos; themed pitch days; pitching competitions; pitch ambassadors and a generic Prezi presentation pitching template.

*Keywords:* new research ideas; pitching; template; research proposal; novice researcher advice; supervisor advice; research mentor advice; PhD coordinator advice

*JEL classifications:* G00; M00; B40; A20; B00; C00; D00; E00; F00; H00; I00; J00; L00; Q00; R00; Z00

## 1. Introduction

Building on Faff's (2015) pitching template, in the current paper I give an update and further explore this methodical approach to pitching a new research proposal.<sup>1</sup> The broad motivation for "pitching research" is as follows. In my experience the TWO biggest obstacles impeding any research project are, quite simply – starting it and finishing it.<sup>2</sup> Moreover, by definition, the latter is only an issue if you manage to successfully negotiate the former. Hence, "pitching research" is all about making a sound start. But, in order to start a research project "with purpose", you need to have a good grasp of where it is you are heading! So, how can you know with any confidence that you have identified a good/worthwhile research topic? More to the point, how can you figure this out very early in the planning process so that you avoid unduly wasting precious time and resources on something that (sadly) might ultimately be seen as a "flimsy" addition to the relevant literature?

Accordingly, the core objective of the current paper is to give tangible advice in this regard.<sup>3</sup> My primary target audience is novice researchers engaged in empirical work – whether they are current doctoral students or (post-PhD) junior academics, with only limited publication experience in the very early phases of an academic career. But, even seasoned researchers might find themselves in the position of having to "pitch" their latest research

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<sup>1</sup> Following a regularly updated revision process, the current paper should be viewed as a "dynamic" companion to the "static" Faff (2015). As such, certain parts of the current paper borrow from Faff (2015).

<sup>2</sup> Once started on a project, a typical researcher will ... "love" the programming ... "love" poring over masses of regression output ... love seeing statistically significant results ... love being in the "middle". After a time, the love affair wanes – especially, when it comes time not just to write up, but to write with purpose, to craft with the reader in mind ... but we all hate writing. This latter challenge I equate to the "85% rule" – i.e. we can usually get a project "85%" done and written up without excessive torture, but then our enthusiasm is fully exhausted. At this stage, our attention is then easily captured by the next "big idea" – which then provides a convenient excuse for dragging out the "endgame". Or, worse still, for never finishing, especially for those who display tendencies of "perfectionism". While the challenge of finishing is all very interesting and important, it goes far beyond the scope of the current paper.

<sup>3</sup> In feedback on a previous version of this paper, it was quite reasonably suggested to me that while the template is helpful, even it can allow/encourage a considerable investment of "wasted" time if the core idea is "dumb". To an extent I agree, though I would argue that implicit in prior versions of this paper was the existence of some preliminary informal discussions between pitcher/pitchee regarding "deal breaker" issues on any given pitch. I now acknowledge and discuss these concerns explicitly in Sub-section 2.2.4. Also, I refer readers to existing papers like Stokes (2013), who provides good advice/strategies on how to generate innovative research ideas. Stokes (2013) is freely available at: [http://www.cig.ase.ro/revista\\_cig/AfiseazaArticol.aspx](http://www.cig.ase.ro/revista_cig/AfiseazaArticol.aspx)

idea.<sup>4</sup> My secondary, but equally important target audience comprises PhD supervisors, research mentors and senior research collaborators, since they should seek out all legitimate means to help fulfil their important leading role in any such research relationship.

To this end, I propose some key guidelines to creating a sound research proposal. Specifically, using Faff's (2015) pitching template, you (the "pitching" researcher) are challenged to concisely "populate" each section of the template with relevant material.

Emphasizing the notion that "less is more", the task is to confine your efforts to just 2 pages.<sup>5</sup>

How would you go about meeting this daunting challenge? What areas/aspects should you cover? In what detail? How can you best package this information for efficient consumption and assessment?

The basic logic is to provide essential, brief information across a broad range of essential dimensions that any collaborator would need, to make a reliable assessment of the quality of and potential for the proposal. Notably, it is assumed that the goal of this exercise is to produce a solid plan which, once executed, would eventually lead to a quality research paper – published as a fully refereed article in a highly reputable international academic journal.

There are numerous extant articles/books that give researchers general advice and valuable insights on how to get their research published and so such a perspective will not be repeated in any detail here. A critical distinction exists between the objective/context of such "advice" papers versus the current paper. Most notably, they assume that researchers already

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<sup>4</sup> There is an analogy in Hollywood –according to Bodey (2015), even a highly credentialed actress like Angelina Jolie still has to interview and pitch for some jobs. As Bodey (2015) reports "... there was no easy path to securing the director's chair on *Unbroken*. Jolie remembers her big pitch for the job, arriving with garbage bags full of "boards and graphs and maps and all these things I'd worked out"..."

<sup>5</sup> In private conversations, Devraj Basu canvassed the view that in some circumstances, and particularly in the first instance when we are trying to capture initial attention, the time constraint might be much more severe than the "luxury" implied by my suggested 30 minutes. The most extreme version involves the so-called "elevator pitch" i.e. the pitcher has to elucidate the "value proposition" in about the time it takes for an elevator ride (30 seconds). This is more akin to the initial "selling" or "thinking" device, which might simply capture the key idea/motivation underlying the proposed research. Alternatively, this hyper-short pitch might be thought of as identifying the "irreducible contribution". Such shorter versions can be viewed as compatible with and subsets of my longer style pitch.

have a well-developed product (i.e. that they have a paper that is considerably beyond the first-draft stage), and the advice they then give is how to enhance and improve from this relatively advanced base. In contrast, in my paper, I am speaking to researchers who have embryonic notions which are yet to be formally explored, and for which the researcher is genuinely unsure of the underlying academic merit.

The remainder of the current paper evolves as follows. In Section 2, I outline Faff's (2015) pitching template and briefly guide the reader as to the underlying thinking behind each piece and how it might be completed. Section 3 provides some advice directed at the two main pitch stakeholders: the "pitcher" and the "pitchee", for completing/using the template. Section 4 provides a review of exemplar pitch templates illustrating its use across a diversity of discipline areas that are available in an Internet library. Section 5 briefly outlines a range of online supplementary material and an update on the ever-growing extensive support and initiatives. The final section concludes.

## **2. The Pitch Template**

### **2.1 Preliminaries**

Faff's (2015) pitch template is shown in Figure 1 in blank format, Figure 2 presents a completed example of the pitch template for "pitching research" proposal itself, while Figure 3 repeats the template but now provides a series of prompting questions, as cues to induce the "pitcher" to think about a range of possible considerations under each heading.<sup>6</sup> I begin by discussing the components of the template and the basic philosophy/purpose behind each element. I also give some general guidance on how to populate each segment of the

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<sup>6</sup> A softcopy WORD file of the pitcher's cued version of the template is available from the authors webpage: <http://www.business.uq.edu.au/staff/details/robert-faff> (please scroll down the webpage until you find the download prompt).

template.<sup>7</sup> For ease of reference, the key elements of the pitch template are labeled “Item (A) - (K)”.

The first thing to understand about the design of the template is a need to be concise and to the point. It is very safe to assume that the “pitchee” (e.g. potential research collaborator, Honours/PhD supervisor, research mentor) is a very busy person. He/she is time poor and in the first instance simply wants to know the essential ideas, without being bogged down by the details. With this in mind, my strong advice is to keep the completed pitch to a maximum of 2 pages. For a knowledgeable “pitchee”, this limit will provide ample material to induce probing questions, leading to an informed judgment – and more detail can be called for once the pitch is deemed “successful”!<sup>8</sup>

Indeed, the pitch can evolve. The very first version will very likely be rough and raw – and possibly incomplete. This is expected. There is no shame in this. Rather, the shame will be if the “pitcher” is always too “scared” to share their pitch with their potential “pitchee” because they fear embarrassment. Air your ideas early, so that they might flourish or die – whichever is appropriate. Lost time is a lost opportunity. Should your early ideas flourish, the pitch template can form a useful framework for development across several iterations, until that moment of metamorphosis is reached – when it is no longer a “pitch” – it becomes a fledgling project!

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<sup>7</sup> Some have voiced concerns (thanks for the lively debate Don and Dusan!) that my advice is too definitive and might be taken by some as a heavily “prescriptive” approach – which, if taken to an extreme, stifles creativity and thinking “out of the box”. While it is true that I am naturally a very risk averse person, I am at pains to stress that the advice is meant to be indicative only. Upon reflection, I believe that the overly “prescriptive” feel to the advice is largely a product of my preoccupation to give tangible examples that make the template’s utility as clear as possible for potential users. Of course, everyone is strongly encouraged to adapt the template (without bounds) to best serve their own needs and agenda. Given the extensive diversity of views across academics, consensus is impossible – hence, my goal is to provide something “imperfectly” useful, rather than chase unreachable “perfection”.

<sup>8</sup> There is no unique definition of “success” in this context. At one extreme, for a very early version of the pitch, success could simply mean that the senior collaborator wants to see a revised pitch that addresses some key areas in more detail. For an already heavily revised pitch, success would be indicated by the senior researcher agreeing to collaborate on the project, with an agreed division of duties on, for example, generating a detailed literature review and hypothesis development versus initial data collection and sampling – perhaps even staged via a “pilot” exercise.

The template begins with stating the pitcher's identity – “ownership” is important.<sup>9</sup> Also a “field of research” (FoR) category clarifies the relevant “domain” and a date of completion of the pitch is provided – so that a clear time context can be given – especially useful in situations when the pitch is (re-)viewed/assessed with any significant delay. The template then covers several broad essential ingredients of which the reader wants immediate knowledge: (A) working title; (B) the basic research question; (C) the key paper(s) and (D) motivation/puzzle.

### *2.1.1 Template Item (A): Working Title*

The “first” challenge is to decide on a working title. While stated as the “first” challenge, in most cases the “working title” evolves over time. As such, the title can be refined several times during the process of completing the template and it becomes more clearly shaped as more information is gathered and cognitively processed. Indeed, you do not necessarily have to begin at the top of the template and work systematically down. The task is best thought of as a dynamic and iterative process, in which the “path” to a completed pitch is non-linear and unpredictable. The ultimate title (of the paper that hopefully comes as a successful output from this pitching process) should be an appropriate balance between being informative, catchy and concise.<sup>10</sup>

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<sup>9</sup> When it comes to “intellectual property” linked to research, a definitive statement of ownership is often problematic. Similar research ideas can be developed independently by different researchers – and it is quite possible that multiple “leaders” will be acknowledged in the literature. One way to stake an early claim to an idea is to make “public” your work in various forms as soon as possible e.g. by creating a working paper on SSRN; by delivering a research workshop at a university seminar program; or by presenting a paper at a recognised conference. Of course, if the idea is meritorious and potentially developed contemporaneously by several researchers, those who are too slow developing it to a mature state, risk being relegated as secondary players on the given issue.

<sup>10</sup> Other things equal, having a short title can attract initial attention. For example, while Benson and Faff (2013), titled “ $\beta$ ”, and Faff (2014) “a” hold the unofficial world record for the shortest title possible and thus has some “curiosity” value, ultimately, papers like these with similarly curt titles, can only sustain attention based on their real academic content.

### 2.1.2 Template Item (B): Basic Research Question

The next challenge<sup>11</sup> is to capture in one sentence, the key features of the chosen research question. It is often said that you should have passion about your research – here I say, be passionate about the question, but as a good scientist, be open-minded about the answer!<sup>12</sup> It is very likely that the research question will be very similar to the working title (Item (A)) – but in most cases it will be more than subtly different, and slightly more expansive. While the question can take almost any form, it is typically “neutral” in its expression. Indeed it might not even be a question, in the literal sense. For example, it might be something like: *What are the (e.g. economic) determinants of “variable Y”?* or *To explore the empirical determinants of “variable Y”*. While such a research question does not identify any prediction(s) or hypothesis(es), it is readily connectable to the expression of such. Following on from the above example, the related hypothesis might be expressed as: *“Variable X” is a positive determinant of “variable Y”* (the opportunity to state a prediction/hypothesis comes later in the template under the Idea). In many contexts, such a statement will clarify the identity of the key dependent (“explained”) variable and the key test/independent (“explanatory”) variable(s).

### 2.1.3 Template Item (C): The Key Papers

A sufficiently deep immersion within the relevant literature is essential to coming up with and confirming a good research topic. I use a light-hearted metaphor to explain how to attack the literature challenge – what I term the “cocktail glass” approach. Imagine a fancy cocktail glass that is very broad at the top, narrows down to a small diameter – say, a third the way from the bottom and then fans out at the base – but much less so than the top. Such a glass is

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<sup>11</sup> Similarly, the “research question” evolves over time. The initial view is often rudimentary and overly simplistic, and it too becomes more clearly shaped as more of the plan comes together.

<sup>12</sup> Putting it another way, if you think that you already “know” the answer before you even start – that your task is simply to find the set of tests that confirm your firmly held beliefs, then you should not embark upon this path at all. The reason is simple – you have no (actual and/or perceived) objectivity and, thus, your research (though very passionate) will not be “truly” independent or “scientific”.

depicted in Figure 4. Symbolically, drinking from the full cocktail glass is like beginning the literature search on a broad topic – there is typically a big literature to traverse, characterized by the big diameter at the top of the glass. As you spend time reading, filtering of the papers takes place, coincident with the refinement of the potential topic – quite likely an iterative process. Like the slow consumption of the cocktail (savoring the taste), the drink level descends toward the narrow part of glass – analogous to the narrowing in ones thinking about which papers within the relevant literature are the most important and critical foundation stones for your research topic. When you get to the narrow part of the glass, you have identified the small set of papers that really help you focus your attention on what is currently “known” and what is still unknown. These are the “key” papers. Later, should the project advance, an expanded set of the most relevant papers is identified as your reference list – like the cocktail glass, these represent the foundation upon which the paper (glass) rests.

I suggest that in answering the question posed in item (C) of the template – namely, what are the “key” foundational papers for your proposal, limit your answer here to just three papers. Indeed, if possible nominate the most critical single paper to your work. You might ask: what “characteristics” should these critical paper(s) possess? Absent any specific considerations to the contrary, I suggest three rules of thumb. First, the key papers should be quite recent – say, no older than 3 years. Ideally, they should be published in the Top Tier journals in the relevant field, or if they are not, then they should be very recent unpublished papers available on SSRN and preferably authored by “gurus” in the relevant field. Collectively, all these conditions serve as heuristics for “currency” and quality.<sup>13</sup>

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<sup>13</sup> Of course, any other objective means of telling that an unpublished paper will soon be an influential one in the Top Tier journals can be used – but the rules of thumb stated in the main text seem reasonably “safe” suggestions.

### *2.1.4 Template Item (D): The Motivation*

The final “preliminary” consideration in the pitch template is the motivation (at item (D)). All high quality papers come with impressive motivation(s). This should emanate from the academic literature itself, but in the social sciences is often also linked to observed (e.g. agent) behavior or actual (e.g. industry) patterns or real market imperatives or current regulation/policy debates. One really good strategy for motivating a paper is isolating a meaningful and relevant “puzzle” – which, for example, might be observed in recent (e.g. market) trends that show curious patterns or actual decision-making that defies conventional wisdom.<sup>14</sup>

The core of the template is built around the “gimmick” of a “3-2-1” design. “Three” represents the three essential ingredients of the Idea, the Data and the Tools. “Two” represents the two basic questions that a successful researcher always convincingly answers: “What’s new?” and “So what?”<sup>15</sup> “One” represents the “holy grail” – the Contribution! Ultimately the merits of any paper must stand on both its actual and perceived contribution to the literature. Each element of the “3-2-1” design is discussed in the following sections.<sup>16</sup>

## **2.2 Three Dimensions – Idea, Data and Tools**

Any empirical paper has three critical dimensions: (1) the Idea; (2) the Data; and (3) the Tools. Faff (2013) proposes a “cheeky” acronym based on the first letters of Idea, Data and

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<sup>14</sup> It is worth noting that many research papers do not identify a “puzzle” in the sense that I have in mind here – there is really a puzzling phenomenon that is observed in “real world” settings, which is not readily explained by the conventional theory/models in a given relevant discipline.

<sup>15</sup> We should always remind ourselves of “cultural sensitivities” – and this is one such case. I have on good authority that from a Chinese perspective, the question “so what?” can be seen as quite offensive. Of course, while I want to challenge the “pitcher”, I do not wish to cause offence! An alternative way of expressing the question is to ask: “who cares?” I thank Yong Li for bringing this issue to my attention and for suggesting the alternative form of the question.

<sup>16</sup> These sections are strongly inspired by and very closely aligned to Section 2 of Faff (2013). Interestingly, in Faff (2013), the purpose at hand – namely, to assess a well-developed paper – is naturally compatible with the reverse order of attack – “1-2-3”. Ultimately, this reversal is innocuous – the essential elements and message remain robust.

Tools – the so-called “IDioTs” guide to empirical research.<sup>17</sup> While the three elements are, for expositional convenience, presented here as being independent considerations, in practice they are often interrelated.

### *2.2.1 Template Item (E): The Idea*

Absent a good idea, irrespective of how impressive everything else is, it is hard to imagine how a worthwhile paper can be created. As stated in Figure 3, against item (E) the main cue asks you to identify the core idea – the essential concept/notion/proposition that drives the intellectual content of your chosen research topic. Moreover, the template prompts for a brief articulation of the central hypothesis and also asks is there any theoretical tension involved? “Theoretical tension” reflects the situation in which there are meaningful contrasting predictions from two (or more) pockets of theory relevant to the research question.<sup>18</sup>

While a critical aspect of a good research idea might very likely come from theory, the motivating idea might not necessarily be exclusively theoretical. As argued by Faff (2013, p. 952), “... the idea might involve an innovative blending of existing theory, or it might actually relate to a clever way of exploiting institutional differences or recognising unique exogenous events that allow reliable identification of causality. The idea might relate to the identification of a “gap”, for which we can’t reliably deduce the answer from the existing literature.”

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<sup>17</sup> In anonymous feedback received on an earlier version of the current paper, the reasonable point was made that these three labels (“idea”, “data”, “tools”) don’t work across all areas of research. For example, in psychology a more accepted labelling might be “hypothesis/research question”, “sample” and “statistical analysis” (HSS). As another example, you might substitute “design” for “data”. In such a case, (research) design would in part capture “data”, but in a broader setting (e.g. qualitative research) allow the thinking to usefully extend beyond this narrower focus. Whatever the case, in my mind, these variations are more about semantics than content. My attraction to “IDioT” is the broad scope that each element conveys, as well as the ease with which we can (collectively) remember them via the light-hearted acronym. It should further be acknowledged that the alternatively suggested labels are also widely used in finance research and elsewhere, though different disciplines might exhibit varying degrees of relaxation with which they are interpreted/applied. Finally, the other positive thing to note here is – whatever the concepts are labelled, it seems that a similarly motivated “triad” is all purposeful. Rather than dismissing on these grounds, a simple mapping from “IDioT” to “HSS” is encouraged!

<sup>18</sup> I do agree with Eliza Wu who, in a private communication, warned that this focus on “tension” can bring the real risk of naively “picking a fight” against a strong and established researcher or research group in which there is little chance of “success”. Experienced mentors are well placed to assess this risk early on, and particularly whether it might be so significant that it becomes a “deal breaker”.

### 2.2.2 Template Item (F): Data

A research paper cannot claim to be truly empirical without data. Item (F) in the template aims to expose key questions around the data and sampling, with a key focus on establishing feasibility of the project – both in terms of an adequate sample size (“quantity”) and veracity of the data source/compilation (“quality”). By challenging the “2 Qs”, the current focus is centred on giving confidence that reliable inferences regarding the question at hand are ultimately deliverable. Item (F) of the template poses a (non-exhaustive) series of data-related questions. Question 1 largely prompts consideration of the chosen unit of analysis – either or both in a longitudinal/time series and a cross-sectional sense. Question 2 can in part be viewed as making us think about statistical validity, since sample size is a key factor.<sup>19</sup> Question 3, probes more on any likely (non-random) structure in the data – e.g. if the data have so-called “panel” properties, the effective degree of independent observations is diminished from the “headline” pooled sample size. Question 4 is strongly asking us to confront feasibility – sources of data whether commercial or hand collected or created by survey methods, pose potentially “deal breaking” issues in terms of prohibitive costs (either monetary or time). Questions 5 and 6 both connect to the veracity issue – missing data, or ambiguous data or “unclean” data. All data are an unknown weighting of signal/information versus “noise”, and concerns reflected in these questions can push the perceived noise/signal ratio beyond levels too high for comfort. As the old saying goes: “garbage in garbage out”. Question (7) in this template item, asks us to contemplate any “other data obstacles?” While this could relate to anything of relevance, it helps prompt thoughts of other validity issues – e.g. external validity: does the sample of data provide a representative and meaningful view

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<sup>19</sup> Clarkson (2012) argues that four dimensions of validity constitute the “cornerstone of scientific rigor”: (a) internal validity – do we have a fully-specified model?; (b) construct validity – do we have compelling linkage between empirical proxies and economic variables?; (c) statistical validity – do we have appropriate data, sampling and tests?; and (d) external validity – will our results be generalizable?

of the underlying (and relevant) population?, or construct validity: are the feasible proxies compelling constructs for the underlying theoretical variables in question?

### *2.2.3 Template Item (G): Tools*

Item (G) reminds us that without adequate tools/techniques, data and ideas are useless. A critical part of academic rigour is having systematic and formally designed statistical analysis that gives reliability/credibility to any/all inferences drawn. An empirical study that is purely descriptive or one that is based on univariate tests, will find little favour in the mainstream literature. In essence, the “toolkit” comprises the techniques, econometric models, software and so on, that collectively allows us to objectively “ask” the data for answers to the key research question and its related predictions/hypotheses. For example, Item (G) asks the very basic question of whether a regression approach will be used. Or will it require survey-based tools (e.g. survey/questionnaire instrument design) or involve interviewing design/techniques? Further, questioning which software (e.g. econometric, text analytics, qualitative) are fit for purpose, prompts the related questions of software availability and training. There is also a question of “connectivity” between tools and all other aspects of the proposed framework – indeed, an overall consideration is that a common thread runs right through the pitch.<sup>20</sup>

As emphasised by Faff (2013, p. 953) novel tools “... can provide added “leverage” to a research question, that helps create new insights not possible with standard techniques that are well-worn in a given literature. One example of such potential leverage is when a researcher transports an established technique from another discipline, and shows how it can give new insights, that for whatever reason are obscured by the existing “old” approaches.”

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<sup>20</sup> I enjoyed discussions with Marc De Ceuster along these lines in which he always asks his students “... what is the *story*?”

#### 2.2.4 The “Deal-breakers”

As foreshadowed in the Introduction, a critique of my advocated approach is that it, too, can allow/encourage a considerable investment of “wasted” time and effort. To minimise this concern, I assume (indeed, advocate that) there (should) be an “sufficient” level of preliminary discussion between pitcher/pitchee regarding the possible existence of any “deal breaker” issues relating to any potential research question before it is fully “embraced” by the template. In the current context, this can most simply be linked back to the “IDioT” principle.

Regarding the Idea, informal “due diligence” should be directed (based on “within reason” efforts) to ruling out: (a) “replication” risk – that you will avoid effectively replicating an existing study; (b) that the answer is already known (directly or indirectly); or (c) that it is a “dumb” idea. Regarding Data, the most common and obvious “deal breaker” to be ruled out is that you do not have access to (or, simply, there do not exist) sufficient quantity/quality data for a reliable and representative sample, relevant to the question. Regarding Tools, it is a question of knowing that the necessary tools are available to do the job. Very likely, it is the Idea and/or the Data which will give most anxiety at this “deal breaker” stage, as modern tools are in abundance. While it is true that all of these “deal-breaker” aspects are relevant to the full pitch template exercise itself, in that context we are interested very much more in specific details for developing the pitch.

### 2.3 Two Questions – What’s New? and So What?

Yes, any “IDioT” can tell you that empirical papers are characterised by three critical dimensions: Idea; Data; and Tools. But, you can use these dimensions either well or poorly – how can you plan to achieve the former and avoid the latter? I suggest the answer lies in two questions! First, ask yourself, what is new? Second, ask so what?

### 2.3.1 *Template Item (H): What is New?*

Faff (2013, p. 951-2) argues that a meaningful contribution should tell us something new, “... something that we did not already know based on an informed reading of the extant literature. If there is no novelty in the empirical work – for example, a straight replication of an existing paper, then it seems straightforward to conclude that there is no contribution.” Moreover, Faff (2013) highlights that novice researchers often fall for the “trap” of taking a very literal interpretation of the word “new”.

Consider a hypothetical illustration, in which a series of single country studies are historically common across a given literature. Viewing this situation, novice researchers can naively fall for the trap of excitedly targeting the “missing” country as a new study. That is, while the relevant literature already documents clear and consistent evidence for country “X”, country “Y” and country “Z”, a perceived “gap” is identified because nothing has been published in the author’s chosen setting of country “A”. Yes, in the narrow (literal) sense, generating a test for country A is “new”. However, the novelty is likely to be deemed trivial – the fallacy here is that an informed reader of this literature (with minimal effort) might be able to take a synthesised view of the collective extant research and reasonably infer what will be applicable to country “A” (and, indeed, to a range of other similar countries). Thus, to establish meaningful novelty in such a single country study, the researcher needs to make a compelling case as to why it is “dangerous” to extrapolate the distilled evidence from X, Y and Z to country A (or to other similar jurisdictions).

Faff (2013, pp. 954-5) emphasises a simple device to help assess research novelty – the so-called “Mickey Mouse” diagram (i.e. Venn diagram). The idea is that based on a characterisation of the relevant literature, you define (e.g. three) circles of research attention

that meaningfully overlap,<sup>21</sup> in ways that have not been completely explored in the extant literature. Figure 5 depicts a generic version of Mickey Mouse, in which two circles are at the top (i.e. “considerations” A and B) representing Mickey’s ears and one circle is at the bottom (i.e. “consideration” C) representing his head. Typically, for projects in which such a characterisation makes sense, the area of novelty is defined by the triple intersection zone i.e. “X marks the spot”.<sup>22</sup>

### 2.3.2 Template Item (I): So What?

Simply being new or novel is not enough! Many “new” things have no special consequence – they are unimportant. Accordingly, Item (I) in the pitch template poses the question, “so what”? Yes, so let’s assume that you have posed a novel research question. But, then the critical follow-up question is – why is it important to know the answer? Is it likely to have “first order” or only “second order” effects? How will major decisions/behaviour/activity and or other relevant phenomenon, be influenced by the outcome of this research? If it is not sufficiently important, then no one will care. To express this concern differently – we should never embark on a research project that is effectively targeting a journal of “irrelevant results”.

Building on the previous discussion, one potentially fruitful way of successfully invoking a “novelty” dimension into a single country study is to identify some unusual (e.g. financial) market behaviour or unusual relevant phenomenon or unique institutional feature or regulatory event(s) that would meaningfully distinguish the chosen new country setting from prior research. But, simply being different to e.g. the US (being the world’s dominant

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<sup>21</sup> There is no fixed requirement for what these circles might represent – they might be any combination of idea(s); data; tools; or relate to market features, regulation, ... anything that makes sense. There is no right or wrong answer here – it is simply a matter of whatever works.

<sup>22</sup> In a sense, the Venn diagram device helps stimulate our thinking toward “innovation” rather than “invention”. While few would argue that “inventing” something very new and path-breaking is not highly valued, for most researchers major “inventions” are purely aspirational and beyond reach. In contrast, innovating with guidance from our friend Mickey is very broadly attainable – and can still deliver fantastic and highly influential outcomes. In the context of doctoral study, the sentiment I convey here is consistent with Mullins and Kiley (2002) – it’s a PhD, not a Nobel prize!

market) does not guarantee a fertile ground for new research. The critical reader (e.g. dissertation examiner or journal referee) will need to be convinced of the importance and relevance of any identified unique features to advancing knowledge in the discipline area. In other words, they will ask the “so what” question.

## **2.4 Template Item (J): One Contribution**

The “holy grail” for any research topic is to make a contribution – this is the **NUMBER ONE** goal. Thus, while few researchers would have trouble agreeing with this statement, no matter how experienced we become at doing research, the challenge of establishing contribution seemingly never becomes any easier. One reason for this is that as we become more experienced, we become more ambitious with our targeted journal – the higher the quality of the journal, the higher is the threshold standard for the required incremental contribution.

Thus, completing the penultimate section of the pitch template is bound to leave us all feeling unsatisfied or even a little disillusioned – but these are not good reasons to leave this item blank or for it to create a “road block”. One comforting thought is that good responses to all of the previous parts of the pitch template, help to define the contribution. In other words, by the time you end up at Item (J), you have thought seriously about all the constituent parts needed for contribution. Now you are faced with the challenge of distilling this into a short statement about the primary force. Often times, it will be inextricably linked to the Idea. But, the Data and the Tools will also play their part. Where is the essence of the novelty? Again, is the Idea new? Is there any novelty in the Data? Is it in the Tools? But, beyond novelty in any of these dimensions, what is the importance? Why should we care? This latter consideration can often invoke thinking around likely economic significance of possible findings. The prospect of finding statistical significance, absent economic significance, is a hollow victory.

## 2.5 Template Item (K): Other Considerations?

Item (K) in Faff's (2015) template is a residual or "catchall" – it presents a time for posing any other relevant final reflections. Various suggestions are offered in the template. Is collaboration needed/desirable? For doctoral students such a question will be a sensitive one – in many cases only limited collaboration will be permitted. Also, the issue of collaboration will give rise to a discussion of roles, expectations and timelines. What are your target journal(s)? Are these targets realistic? Are they relevant? Sufficiently ambitious? Or, too ambitious?

Also, what about a "risk" assessment? While totally subjective, can you make a judgment on whether the proposed project has "low" vs. "moderate" vs. "high" risk, in certain respects? For example, the risk of "insignificant results"?<sup>23</sup> Or that of "competitor" risk (i.e. being beaten to publication by a strong competitor)? Or the risk of "obsolescence"? Is there any other major (research) risk exposure? Also, are there any serious challenge(s) that you face in executing this plan? If so, what are they? Are they related to the Idea? The Data? The Tools?

Finally, what about the implied scope of proposed analysis? Is the scope appropriate for the purpose or goal? Should it be narrower thereby allowing a deeper examination versus being broader and more shallow? These considerations of scope are often at issue in "conversations" between Honours/PhD students and their supervisors.<sup>24</sup>

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<sup>23</sup> In conversations with Devraj Basu, I was reminded of a strategy that many of us have used to circumvent the "no results" risk, that might also be seen as a "deal-breaker" consideration. Specifically, we can ask for a "proof of concept" analysis in which just one basic table and/or graph of basic results is required – often within a challenging but feasible timeframe (e.g. delivery required within 4 weeks or else the collaboration offer dissolves).

<sup>24</sup> Of course, there is an important distinction between the appropriate scope of an Honours thesis versus a PhD – most simply thought of in terms of the differential timeframe constraint, 9 months versus 36 months. For example, it is not uncommon for an Honours student to be advised that their topic is too broad – "... hey, that's a PhD – you won't have time to do justice to that topic ... we need to cut this down."

### **3. General Advice on Using the Template**

#### **3.1 Advice to the “Pitcher” – PhD students and Novice Researchers**

To this point, since the current paper has predominantly been written with the pitcher in mind, further detailed commentary under this heading is unnecessary. As already stated above, I plead with the pitcher – don’t be scared! Treat the pitch template as your “friend”, here to help you start a “conversation” with a relevant expert – a supervisor, a mentor, a potential collaborator. Among other things, I argue that this offers a big advantage in inducing better, more targeted feedback on your ideas. But, please take early and serious notice of the potential “deal breakers” (see Sub-section 2.2.4). Be concise and focused – “less is more”, until “more” is requested. Think of it from the pitchee’s point of view – what would you like to know if you were on the “other side”? View the pitch as a starting point only – don’t suffer from the pitfall of “perfectionism” – particularly at such an early stage of the research process, just get your core ideas down. Appreciate the benefit that the template gives in terms of organizing your thoughts in a concise/structured way.

#### **3.2 Advice to the “Pitchee” – Supervisors/Research Mentors**

Hey! It’s a two-way street! As a “pitchee” you need to know how to help the pitcher get the best from the exercise. Above all be supportive and encouraging. But, please be vigilant and pro-active on the question of potential “deal breakers” (see Sub-section 2.2.4) – this is where your experience and expertise are vitally important! Any *bona fide* effort – that produces a seriously completed pitch, however “flawed” it may be, is a success! In the embryonic stages, these exercises help us more quickly and efficiently move on a positive research trajectory. As such, the pitch template offers big advantages to you, the pitchee. Used wisely, if nothing else, it can help save you a lot of time and avoid much frustration. To assist even further in

this regard, in the online material I provide a counterpart pitcher's version of the (pitcher's) cued template in Figure 3.<sup>25</sup>

As a pitcher, you have a "duty of care" to the potential pitcher.<sup>26</sup> As such, you should devise a "pre-pitch" strategy in which you aim to help minimise the chance of an early/any repeated "dead end(s)" for your protégé. To this end, they will want early guidance on what ideas are worth thinking more about and which ones are not? They will want guidance on how to efficiently generate a "pool" of potential research directions. In this regard, there are several strands of advice I can offer.

First, emphasize very early on to the pitcher the need to follow a "smart" (cocktail glass) approach to reading the literature and to quickly run ideas past you. Second, advise your pitcher to read works like Stokes (2013) to gain a strategic mindset that can enhance their ability e.g. to scan the literature. Third, recommend that the pitcher seek out recent survey articles written by "gurus" in the field relating to their broad topic areas of interest.<sup>27</sup> Finally, particularly with Honours or MSc students in mind, you could apply the "four-eyes" (4 x "i"s) principle, where "i" here prompts layered questioning around the student's academic discipline-related "interests".<sup>28</sup> The first "i" asks the student what Major in their coursework study do they find most *interesting*? Second, within that major what subject is most *interesting*? Third, within that subject what topic is most *interesting*? And fourth, within

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<sup>25</sup> A softcopy WORD file of the pitcher's cued version of the template is available from the authors webpage: <http://www.business.uq.edu.au/staff/details/robert-faff> (please scroll down the webpage until you find the download prompt).

<sup>26</sup> Not everyone agrees with the implied "risk averse" stance that I take here as a supervisor/mentor. Some argue that such an approach could easily stifle a brilliant student/brilliant topic that could lead to a major seminal work in a given field. There is no right or wrong answer here – it is a judgment call that we all need to make for ourselves, in terms of how we execute our "duty of care".

<sup>27</sup> An excellent source of such review articles spanning a broad range of discipline areas is *Annual Reviews* [<http://www.annualreviews.org/>], for example, including (a) biomedical/life sciences: biochemistry, biophysics, clinical psychology, genetics, marine science, medicine, physiology, virology; (b) physical sciences: biophysics, computer science, fluid mechanics, physical chemistry; (c) social sciences: anthropology, economics, financial economics, political science, psychology, sociology, to name but a few. As stated on their website, the "... mission of Annual Reviews is to provide systematic, periodic examinations of scholarly advances in a number of fields of science through critical authoritative reviews. The comprehensive critical review not only summarizes a topic but also roots out errors of fact or concept and provokes discussion that will lead to new research activity."

<sup>28</sup> I thank my colleague, Barry Oliver, for suggesting (and naming) this simple but effective approach.

that topic what subtopic or vexing issue is most *interesting*? This simple, “drill down” approach can help usefully narrow the field, which can further be filtered by questions of their current/potential skillset (e.g. which areas did the student get their best marks) and their “confidence/comfort” (e.g. which area does the student feel most confident about studying in great depth from a research perspective).

A few further words of advice, particularly to novice/junior pitchers. Try and think of it from the pitcher’s point of view – in particular, from a position of: perceived/actual ignorance about the technical aspects of the topic, a fear of being foolish and not knowing what is really important at the beginning. Once a completed pitch is in hand, identify the strengths/weaknesses. Applaud the strengths! Make it clear why such aspects are deemed strengths. Offer guidance on the weaknesses – specific or general. Aim to help develop the pitch to be uniformly strong.

You could formally rate a completed pitch – a simple “10x10” = 100 score (relating to Items (B)-(K)). Moreover, you as the pitcher could request the pitcher to perform a similar independent self-assessment. Then, at a first meeting after the pitch has been created and “assessed”, you could do an element by element “revelation” and comparison of scores, as well as the overall score. This could be used as a targeted heuristic for identifying strengths/weaknesses and help set an agenda/priorities for discussing strategies for future improvement. As the pitcher, you could also assess what you believe to be the *upper bound* for each template Item – element by element and therefore of the overall score.<sup>29</sup>

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<sup>29</sup> For example, in the context of a PhD essay and in terms of “overall” score, I can think of three values for comparison: (a) the self-assessed PhD student’s total score (e.g. hypothetically, say, 85); (b) the supervisor’s assessed total actual score (e.g. hypothetically, say, 60); and (c) the supervisor’s assessed potential score (e.g. hypothetically, say, 80). In the hypothetical case above, there are three “expectation gaps” for discussion between the student and the supervisor: (i) (a) vs. (b) – i.e. 85 vs. 60; (ii) (b) vs. (c) – i.e. 60 vs. 80; and (iii) (a) vs. (c) – i.e. 85 vs. 80. A similar comparison can take place at the Item by Item level.

#### 4. Exemplar Completed Pitch Templates across a Diverse Range of Discipline Areas

Table 1 summarizes a growing library of completed pitch templates across a broad range of academic disciplines – the aggregated and separate components of which are all available in online Internet Appendix A.<sup>30</sup> In Appendix A1, two examples in the corporate finance area are provided. Example 1 is a pitch relating to capital structure and comes with a detailed commentary of how the pitch is constructed. Corporate finance pitch example 2 relates to financial flexibility, credit re-ratings and corporate decisions and is a “reverse engineering” exercise relating to the existing paper by Agha and Faff (2014).<sup>31</sup>

Internet Appendix A2 provides two illustrative examples of completed pitch templates on accounting topics, namely, on: (a) financial reporting and the GFC (EG1);<sup>32</sup> and (b) executive remuneration and firm financial performance (EG2).<sup>33</sup> In both cases I have given the pitchers feedback on their efforts – in the former case using Word “balloons”, while in the latter case I have highlighted in yellow the words/phrases that “stuck out” to me when reading the pitch. In either case the goal is to start a “conversation” – for example, in EG2 my opening question to the pitchers would simply be: as a package, do the highlighted words represent the most important messages in your pitch? And, following this a more targeted discussion can home in on individual aspects of the pitch that stand out – but, with an open mind that other issues will naturally arise as a result of the interactive discussion.

In Internet Appendix A3, I present a short “evolutionary” example relating to a CSR-focused pitch.<sup>34</sup> As was the case with the EG1 accounting example above, I present (a) the original version; (b) original plus feedback (via “balloon” e-comments); and (c) the revised

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<sup>30</sup> Online Internet Appendix A can be accessed at (please scroll down the webpage until you find the relevant weblink prompt): <http://www.business.uq.edu.au/supplementary-material-pitching-research>

<sup>31</sup> I am very grateful to Saphira Rekker for completing the template under this “reverse engineering” scenario.

<sup>32</sup> In this case, the pitcher has actually written up a short “letters” type paper that gives a brief commentary on the pitch and then offers a few key personal reflections on the pitch exercise itself – see Ratiu (2014 & 2015).

<sup>33</sup> I am very grateful to Raluca Ratiu (EG1) and Stacey Beaumont and Robyn King (EG2) for completing the respective templates and giving their permission to openly share them in the context of the current paper. See also Beaumont (2014, 2015).

<sup>34</sup> I am very grateful to Marion Dupire-Declerck for completing the template and (together with her mentor, Bouchra M’Zali) giving permission to openly share it in the context of the current paper.

pitch taking account of the comments (highlighted yellow sections indicate the main changes). In Internet Appendix A4, I present an illustrative example of completed pitch template in an inter-disciplinary setting, namely, sustainable systems/consumer behavior.<sup>35</sup> In Internet Appendix A5, I present two illustrative pitch examples of qualitative projects. The first pitch (A5.1) ironically proposes analysis of whether and to what extent qualitative projects are suited to the structured template approach.<sup>36</sup> While containing an element of “tongue in cheek”, this example of the template aims to rebut the claim in earlier versions of the current paper that the template is ill-suited to the qualitative research domain. The second example (A5.2) is an “interpretive” qualitative pitch looking at the legitimacy of current corporate tax practices in Australia.<sup>37</sup>

In Internet Appendix A6, I present an illustrative example of completed pitch template in management, proposing to examine how universities engage with controversial industries using a case study approach.<sup>38</sup> In Internet Appendix A7 we have an illustrative example of completed pitch template in chemistry – specifically, Paleobiogeochemistry /Geochemistry looking at the change in temperature of Australia’s oceans using biomarker records. It should be noted that this particular pitch is a “reverse engineered” example based on the pitcher’s completed Honours thesis at the Australian National University in 2011.<sup>39</sup>

In Internet Appendix A8 specific advice is given about using the template in a Mechanical Engineering setting from the perspective of an Honours student in this field

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<sup>35</sup> I am very grateful to Saphira Rekker for completing the template and giving her permission to openly share it in the context of the current paper.

<sup>36</sup> I am very grateful to Ingrid Nielsen for completing the template (pretending to be an Honours student) and giving her permission to openly share it in the context of the current paper.

<sup>37</sup> I am very grateful to Mattia Anesa for completing the template and giving her permission to openly share it in the context of the current paper.

<sup>38</sup> I am very grateful to Lis Hardie for completing the template and giving her permission to openly share it in the context of the current paper.

<sup>39</sup> I am very grateful to Marita Smith for completing the template and giving her permission to openly share it in the context of the current paper.

(A8.1), in addition to an actual mechanical engineering pitch example (A8.2).<sup>40</sup> Internet Appendix A9 shows an example in the broad area of computer science, focusing on a pitch for a “robotics” topic.<sup>41</sup> Internet Appendix A10 provides an example for mathematics asking do football teams in the Australian National Rugby League play up to their potential.<sup>42</sup>

Finally, Internet Appendices A11-A30 show examples for: physics (A11); healthcare (A12); psychology (A13); strategy (A14); governance (A15);<sup>43</sup> sport (A16); energy policy (A17); climate change (A18); research policy (A19); taxation (A20); banking (A21); behavioural finance (A22); public policy and regulation (A23), education (A24); market microstructure (A25); information systems (A26); immunology (A27); biology (A28); management accounting (A29); multidisciplinary (climate science) (A30); accounting theory (A31); accounting history (A32); archaeology (A33); behavioural economics (A34); humour (A35); phytology (A36); organic chemistry (A37), respectively.<sup>44</sup>

## 5. Supplementary Material, Support and Initiatives

The original version of the “pitching research” paper was lodged on SSRN on 3 July, 2014. By 15 July, 2015 the first through ninth versions of the paper (combined) have logged **3,931** downloads. As a result, quite a flow of email traffic has been received regarding the paper and the responses so far have been universally positive and encouraging. Online Internet

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<sup>40</sup> I am very grateful to Suyash Mahto for thoughtfully compiling the advice in the template, along with his own example and giving his permission to openly share both in the context of the current paper.

<sup>41</sup> I am very grateful to Lexie Yao for completing the template and giving her permission to openly share it in the context of the current paper.

<sup>42</sup> I am very grateful to Daniel Murray for completing the template and giving his permission to openly share it in the context of the current paper.

<sup>43</sup> In this case, the pitcher has actually written up a short “letters” type paper that gives a brief commentary on the pitch and then offers a few key personal reflections on the pitch exercise itself – see Unda (2014 & 2015).

<sup>44</sup> I am very grateful to Harry Mulgrew, Wanvipha Hongnaphadol, Ria Vaportzis, Paul Newbury, Luisa Unda, Hengsheng Nie, Sid Song, Geoff Warren, Jac Birt, Dave Michayluk, Mone Andrias, Marita Smith, David Smith, Gabriel Donleavy, Ross Skelton for completing these templates and giving their permission to openly share each of their efforts in the context of the current paper.

Appendix C documents a range of anonymous feedback.<sup>45</sup> The current version of the paper has taken on board many elements of the above (and other) feedback. Moreover, this feedback has helped to motivate the development of a range of supplementary material, support and initiatives as briefly described below.

### 5.1 Prezi Presentation Template

While the original and primary philosophy underlying the pitch template relates to a **private** “conversation” between the pitcher and pitchee, undoubtedly it has broader application. For example, a pitcher might be faced with the challenge of conveying their ideas to a room full of people. Accordingly, I offer a Prezi presentation format to more effectively present the pitch template to a bigger audience – for those cases in which the research pitch is executed in a public forum. To this end, a generic version based on Figure 3 is available online.<sup>46</sup>

### 5.2 Extended Advice to Third Parties

Aside from the core stakeholder – the “pitcher” (Honours student, PhD student, novice researcher) – followed closely by the “pitchee” (supervisor, research mentor or potential collaborator), there are several third-party stakeholders whom might benefit from the current paper and its associated template.<sup>47</sup> I have several main categories in mind: the research methods “instructor”; the postgraduate coordinator and the doctoral symposium organizer. I offer a range of general advice for each category in online Internet Appendix D.<sup>48</sup>

### 5.3 “Pitch Days” and Pitching Competitions

Several pitch days have been held over the past several months aimed at providing a “critical mass” and support for young researchers pitching their early ideas. In each instance, a

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<sup>45</sup> Online Internet Appendix C can be accessed at (please scroll down the webpage until you find the relevant weblink prompt): <http://www.business.uq.edu.au/supplementary-material-pitching-research>

<sup>46</sup> I am very grateful to Lexie Yao for sharing with me her Prezi presentation (and Rand Low for his advice), which I adapted to create this generic version. Please access the Prezi template at: [https://prezi.com/0h9e\\_9vol1le/pitchtemplate\\_master\\_withcues\\_1/](https://prezi.com/0h9e_9vol1le/pitchtemplate_master_withcues_1/)

<sup>47</sup> To assist third-party users, a set of PowerPoint slides is available at (please scroll down the webpage until you find the relevant weblink prompt): <http://www.business.uq.edu.au/staff/robert-faff>

<sup>48</sup> Online Internet Appendix D can be accessed at (please scroll down the webpage until you find the relevant weblink prompt): <http://www.business.uq.edu.au/supplementary-material-pitching-research>

pitching competition was held in conjunction to encourage participation and effort.<sup>49</sup> The first of these events occurred in October 2014, where 9 pitchers presented at Latrobe University (Melbourne) and Luisa Unda won the best pitch award. In February 2015, coincidentally again 9 pitchers lined up for a pitch day sponsored by SIRCA, themed around using the SIRCA database. On this occasion the best pitch award was won by Martin Hauptfleisch (University of Technology Sydney). In late May 2015, CIFR sponsored a “public policy and regulation” pitching event in which 12 pitches were “thrown”.<sup>50, 51</sup> The winner of that event was Marvin Wee. More recently, in June 2015 10 pitchers gathered in Bucharest, Romania, to pitch their research at a specially dedicated stream of the 10<sup>th</sup> AMIS conference. George Cordos was the winner of this pitching competition. In the most recently completed event, 35 pitches were submitted at the AFAANZ Doctoral Symposium in July 2015. Congratulations to Amirul Nasir (and indeed all the other winners mentioned above) for creating the best written AFAANZ pitch. In an upcoming event at the University of Queensland, a university wide competition has already garnered expressions of interest from diverse areas of research including: public health, medicine, social work, tourism, sustainability, accounting, bio-science, mechanical engineering, mining engineering, chemistry, natural gas engineering and plant science.

#### **5.4 Doctoral Symposia and Doctoral Education**

There have been several groups of PhD students exposed to the pitching concept at doctoral/ECR symposia around the world. This all began with the paper development workshop sponsored by IAEER/ACCA in June 2013, held at the Bucharest University of Economic Studies. The International Accounting and Finance Doctoral Symposium (IAFDS)

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<sup>49</sup> I am open to suggestions for new similar future initiatives – readers are invited to contact me with brief proposals.

<sup>50</sup> See [http://www.cifr.edu.au/site/Latest\\_news/CIFR\\_Pitching\\_Research\\_Symposium.aspx](http://www.cifr.edu.au/site/Latest_news/CIFR_Pitching_Research_Symposium.aspx)

<sup>51</sup> An alternative cued template with advice on how to slant the pitch to public policy/regulation was specially created for this event and a softcopy WORD version is available from the authors webpage: <http://www.business.uq.edu.au/staff/details/robert-faff> (please scroll down the webpage until you find the download prompt).

has also hosted pitching themes in 2013 (University of Bologna, Italy); 2014 (Trondheim University, Norway) and 2015 (University of Ljubljana, Slovenia). Finally, PhD students at the AFAANZ Doctoral Symposium were exposed to the pitching concept in 2014 (Auckland, New Zealand) and 2015 (Hobart, Australia).

In 2015, AFAANZ created a Doctoral Education Network (AFDEN) to encourage and help enable the broad offering of a rich suite of doctoral-level subjects suitable for accounting and finance students in their first year of study, leading up to PhD Confirmation.<sup>52</sup> As part of AFDEN, a course titled “The Research Process” has a core element on “pitching research”.

### **5.5 Research Grants**

AFAANZ have an annual grants program designed to provide “seed” funding for small research projects, particularly focused on early career researchers. Since its inception over 10 years ago, this grant scheme has disbursed a total exceeding \$1.5 million in competitive funding to worthy novice researchers. In all years prior to the most recent funding round, a very traditional approach has been used for such grant applications. Persuaded by the argument that applying for research funding is a classic case of the challenges faced by novices starting research, AFAANZ adopted the pitch template as a core part of its required grant application.<sup>53, 54</sup>

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<sup>52</sup> <http://www.afaanz.org/doctoral-programs#AFAANZDOCTORALEducationNetwork>

<sup>53</sup> This year 88 applications were received. For a full list of the successful recipients of these grants in the most recent round see

[http://www.afaanz.org/images/stories/pdfs/general\\_pdf/2015\\_AFAANZ\\_Research\\_Grant\\_Recipients.pdf](http://www.afaanz.org/images/stories/pdfs/general_pdf/2015_AFAANZ_Research_Grant_Recipients.pdf)

<sup>54</sup> An example of an actual successful AFAANZ grant illustrating the use of the pitch template framework is available from the authors webpage: <http://www.business.uq.edu.au/staff/details/robert-faff> (please scroll down the webpage until you find the download prompt).

## 5.6 YouTube Video Resources

Several of the “pitching” sessions have been recorded and freely available for anyone to view/use. One of the earliest workshops presented at Monash University on 14 August, 2014 was recorded and the video is available on YouTube.<sup>55</sup> A similar recording is available from another early presentation that I did at the University of Queensland (for UQAPS).<sup>56</sup> In a follow up session at the University of Queensland more recently,<sup>57</sup> four example pitches are recorded: (a) sustainable systems;<sup>58</sup> (b) accounting;<sup>59</sup> (c) chemistry;<sup>60</sup> and (d) archaeology.<sup>61</sup>

## 5.7 Social Media and Marketing

Striving to keep up with the latest trends in getting an important message out on a mass scale, I have recently entered the “lion’s den” of social media. My main focus on this front has been via LinkedIn. Currently, I have in excess of **2,750** followers and I am very keen to expand this much further, in terms of my core target audience. My exclusive focus on LinkedIn is to keep my network updated and well informed about pitch-related activities and developments via regular “posts”. To date I have 11 different posts, of which there are two main types: (a) from the “pitch doctor” (e.g. “The pitch doctor heads to Romania”)<sup>62</sup> and (b) “pitch of the week” (“Multi-robot systems: Implementing genetic algorithms”).<sup>63</sup>

The “pitch doctor” persona has been developing over time, aimed at giving an engaging lighter-moment feel to my passion and drive to help novice researchers make that very important first step in the research jungle. The main idea behind the “pitch of the week” series is to give brief personal background information about the pitcher being showcased, as

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<sup>55</sup> The workshop is also accessible from the “supplementary material” weblink on my UQ webpage (scroll down):

<http://www.business.uq.edu.au/supplementary-material-pitching-research>

<sup>56</sup> This video is available at: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0u6PX4hPubY>

<sup>57</sup> A video of the Introduction to this “pitch examples” session is available at: <https://youtu.be/ruL9ZYOfv5k>

<sup>58</sup> This video is available at: <https://youtu.be/QBo2wU0z18o>

<sup>59</sup> This video is available at: <https://youtu.be/mjBBRnN6gwY>

<sup>60</sup> This video is available at: <https://youtu.be/PmjM9XfxZ4E>

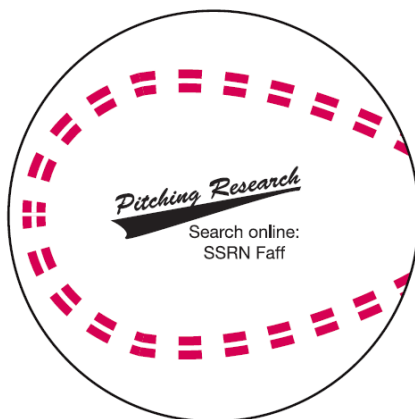
<sup>61</sup> This video is available at: <https://youtu.be/AylMABEq4Cc>

<sup>62</sup> <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/pitch-doctor-heads-romania-robert-faff?trk=mp-author-card>

<sup>63</sup> <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/pitch-week-multi-robot-systems-robert-faff?trk=mp-author-card>

a “human interest” angle, supplementing the actual pitch example itself. If all this sounds very interesting to you, I will welcome your invitation to me to “connect” with you on LinkedIn!<sup>64</sup> Indeed, I especially encourage you to “link” with me if you are interested in academic research, in any way, shape or form – without prejudice, whether you are a novice researcher or not.<sup>65</sup>

Those who have already attended one of my pitching sessions know that I also have a physical marketing gimmick – a “stressball” in the shape of a baseball. There are two relevant metaphors at play here. First, is the obvious baseball analogy of “pitching” – you pitch a baseball and you pitch your research. Second, is the more subtle link to the stressball, per se. Just like many challenging aspects of our lives, doing research is stressful. Starting research is **very** stressful. Starting research as a novice is **hyper** stressful. Just like a stressball, the pitching concept and template is designed to relieve your stress!



## 5.8 Audience Heterogeneity

Initially, I was very cautious in how I approached the goal of selling the “pitching” message to academic audiences – best exemplified by the fact that I spoke only to those belonging to my own research area, accounting and finance. As time has elapsed, buoyed by the positive feedback shown after each episode, I have become more confident about the generic value of

<sup>64</sup> <https://www.linkedin.com/in/robertfaff>

<sup>65</sup> I have also created a Twitter presence, though because this medium is still a big “mystery” to me, I am much less focused on this social media avenue than I am on LinkedIn. Indeed, I more see Twitter as a supplement to leveraging exposure to my LinkedIn activity. But, please follow me on Twitter: @FaffRobert

the approach. This has allowed me to engage with audiences outside my comfort zone, for example: to management PhD students in December 2014 (ANZAM), to international business students in February 2015 (ANZIBA), and in recent months to psychology, clinical research and pharmacy students and academics at the University of Queensland. While extremely challenging, this broad focus is extremely rewarding.

### 5.9 Pitching Research Letters

The editors of *Journal of Accounting and Management Information Systems* (JAMIS) have announced the launch of *Pitching Research Letters* (PRL), to be fully incorporated as a new dedicated section in JAMIS.<sup>66</sup> As stated by the JAMIS Editors, PRL is a new “letters” style section of JAMIS targeting PhD students and, more generally, novice researchers in the accounting, information systems and finance disciplines (broadly defined) – that is, targeting novice researchers in the research domain traditionally serviced by JAMIS. Such researchers are invited to complete a research “pitch” and write a brief discussion of their pitch according to a prescribed “letter” format – along the lines of Beaumont (2015), Ratiu (2015) and Unda (2015).<sup>67</sup>

### 5.10 Pitch Ambassadors

If you are a co-ordinator of an Honours/Masters cohort of students I openly invite you to become a “pitch ambassador”. The inaugural pitch ambassador is Dr Marvin Wee at the University of Western Australia. The ambassador role offers a range of benefits: sponsorship of best pitch award within a given cohort (minimum of 10 enrolled students); supply of

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<sup>66</sup> See PRL announcement and call at: [http://www.cig.ase.ro/revista\\_cig/](http://www.cig.ase.ro/revista_cig/)

<sup>67</sup> As stated in the publicity from JAMIS, this unique opportunity is designed to provide a range of developmental objectives: (a) serve as an important exercise for novice researchers, allowing them to explain their research plans clearly and succinctly; (b) allow them to publicly “stake a claim” over a specific research question [in effect to serve as a “registered” PRL pitch]; and (c) offer novice researchers a meaningful publication avenue that they would not readily find elsewhere. Crucially, JAMIS have wisely notified that upon request from submitting authors, the editors will agree to an “embargo” period of up to 12 months – that is, the accepted PRL paper in question will have an agreed minimum delay in publication as measured from the date of acceptance.

stressballs to all enrolled students; the possibility of arranging a special pitch talk or helping to run a pitch day and/or facilitation pitch feedback to students.<sup>68</sup>

### **5.11 World Tour**

I am thoroughly committed to spreading the “pitching” message as far and wide as is humanly possible. In so doing, I take the view that while ever there continue to be willing hosts, the perceived value in the pitching concept is real and expanding. The first pitch seminar based on the current paper took place at Deakin University on 12 August 2014. Since then I have given versions of the pitch talk 64 times. Notably, this list includes 22 of the 40 universities in Australia. Outside of Australia, to date I have presented five times in New Zealand, at six German universities, three Chinese universities, and two Scottish universities, as well as in Romania, Belgium, Slovenia and France. Later in July, I will present in South America (Mexico and Argentina). I continue to welcome the opportunity to travel and invest time and effort in new locations and new researchers.

### **5.12 Dedicated “PitchMyResearch.com” Website**

In just a very short time, the pitching template introduced by Faff (2015) has gained much exposure and use in Australia and around the world. But, beyond its intuitive appeal, can we measure and optimise the impact of the “template” empirically? This question motivates an AFAANZ-sponsored project that I have jointly with Dr Keith Godfrey (University of Western Australia). With an explicit focus on accounting and finance research, the aim of the project is to document the benefits of template pitching and to develop measures to improve the cues and training. Moreover, one of the lasting benefits from this AFAANZ project will be a web portal for use by students, researchers, and supervisors when creating and reviewing research pitches: “PitchMyResearch.com”.<sup>69</sup> Registration is free. As the AFAANZ project develops, users will be able to create private pitches, or select other users for collaboration

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<sup>68</sup> For anyone interested in this ambassador role please contact me to discuss details.

<sup>69</sup> The very preliminary first version of the web portal (currently with limited functionality) can be trialled at: <http://www.PitchMyResearch.com>

and review. The on-line streamlining of the pitching and review processes will be a valuable contribution on top of the research outcomes. While the focus of this project with Keith is narrowly positioned in the “accounting and finance” space (i.e. linked to the core charter of the funding body, AFAANZ), I have ambitious plans to expand it more broadly in the future.<sup>70</sup>

## 6. Conclusion

Following a regularly updated revision process, the current paper is a “dynamic” companion to Faff (2015). Specifically, in the current paper I further explore a methodical approach to pitching a new research proposal, enabled by Faff’s pitching template. This simple template is designed to allow a researcher in virtually any academic discipline to identify the core elements of a viable and worthwhile empirical research proposal. The template is built around the core “gimmick” of a “3-2-1” countdown design. **Three** represents the essential ingredients of Idea, Data and Tools. **Two** represents the two basic questions a researcher has to convincingly answer: “What’s new?” and “So what?” **One** represents the “holy grail” Contribution! I hope that this template will be of great use as a training tool for developing strong research proposals by the leading researchers of the future. While the current paper is now in its tenth major version, I will continue striving hard to broaden its appeal to all possible areas of academic endeavour.

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<sup>70</sup> Specifically, I am developing a much deeper and more ambitious version named “**i-TEMPLATE**”: internet-Technology Enhanced Mobile-mentored Pitch Learning Across Tertiary Education Spectra.

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**Table 1: Summary of Exemplar Completed Pitches using Faff's (2015) Pitching Template available in the Online Internet Library**

| Appendix | Topic Area                                                 | Pitch Title                                                                                                                                                                                           | Pitcher(s)                                         | Affiliation                         |
|----------|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| A1.1     | Corporate Finance (EG1)                                    | "Explaining the Trade-off Theory Puzzle with a Unified Theory of Capital Structure"                                                                                                                   | Robert Faff                                        | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A1.2     | (EG2)                                                      | "An investigation of the link between Credit Re-ratings and Corporate Financial Decisions; the effect of Financial Flexibility" (reverse engineered)                                                  | Saphira Rekker                                     | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A2.1     | Accounting (EG1)                                           | "Financial Reporting of European Financial Institutions During the GFC" (2 versions: (a) original; (b) original with feedback)                                                                        | Raluca Ratiu                                       | Babes-Bolyai University, Romania    |
| A2.2     | (EG2)                                                      | "An Investigation of the Short and Long Run Relations Between Executive Cash Bonus Payments and Firm Financial Performance" (3 versions: (a) original; (b) original with feedback; (c) revised pitch) | Stacey Beaumont & Robyn King                       | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A3       | Corporate Social Responsibility                            | "CSR strategies in response to competitive pressure" (3 versions: (a) original; (b) original with feedback; (c) revised pitch)                                                                        | Marion Dupire-Declerck, mentored by Bouchra M'Zali | SKEMA, France                       |
| A4       | Inter-disciplinary: sustainable systems/consumer behaviour | "Converting planetary boundaries into action: A new approach to meeting global greenhouse gas targets"                                                                                                | Saphira Rekker                                     | University of Queensland            |
| A5.1     | Qualitative (EG1)                                          | "Understanding why ECRs might use a Pitching Template"                                                                                                                                                | Ingrid Nielsen                                     | Deakin University, Australia        |
| A5.2     | EG2                                                        | "Understanding the emergence, adoption and perceived impacts of corporate tax practices in Australia"                                                                                                 | Mattia Anesa                                       | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A6       | Management                                                 | "How do universities engage with controversial industries? A case-study of onshore/unconventional gas research programs funded by industry"                                                           | Liz Hardie                                         | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A7       | Chemistry                                                  | "Molecular biomarker records of Australian sea-surface temperatures over the past five centuries"                                                                                                     | Marita Smith                                       | Australian National University      |
| A8.1     | Mechanical Engineering                                     | General advice about using the template to research students in this field                                                                                                                            | Suyash Mahto                                       | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A8.2     |                                                            | "Investigation of a theoretical function to describe damping in conveyor belts under non-steady state conditions"                                                                                     | Suyash Mahto                                       | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A9       | Computer Science                                           | "Alternative way to play multi-robot games: Implementing genetic algorithms in game theory"                                                                                                           | Lexie Yao                                          | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A10      | Mathematics                                                | "Measuring efficiency in the National Rugby League"                                                                                                                                                   | Daniel Murray                                      | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A11      | Physics                                                    | "Going Around the Loop: Modelling fermions in a Sagnac Interferometer"                                                                                                                                | Harry Mulgrew                                      | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A12      | Healthcare                                                 | "Negotiating role identities of Thai and Japanese healthcare interpreters at Thai private hospitals"                                                                                                  | Wanvipha Hongnaphadol                              | Kasetsart University, Thailand      |
| A13      | Psychology                                                 | "The Effectiveness of a Six-Month Dance Intervention in Parkinson's Disease and the Elderly"                                                                                                          | Ria Vaportzis                                      | Monash University, Australia        |
| A14      | Strategy                                                   | Expediting the transition to low-carbon electric power systems in developing economies: A comparative study of China and India using a Sectoral Systems of Innovation (SSI) framework approach        | Paul Newbury                                       | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A15      | Governance                                                 | "Board of Directors Characteristics and Credit Union Financial Performance"                                                                                                                           | Luisa Unda                                         | LaTrobe University                  |
| A16      | Sport                                                      | "Measuring efficiency in the National Rugby League"                                                                                                                                                   | Daniel Murray                                      | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A17      | Energy Policy                                              | Expediting the transition to low-carbon electric power systems in developing economies: A comparative study of China and India using a Sectoral Systems of Innovation (SSI) framework approach        | Paul Newbury                                       | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A18      | Climate Change                                             | "Molecular biomarker records of Australian sea-surface temperatures over the past five centuries"                                                                                                     | Marita Smith                                       | Australian National University      |
| A19      | Research Policy                                            | "How do universities engage with controversial industries? A case-study of onshore/unconventional gas research programs funded by industry"                                                           | Liz Hardie                                         | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A20      | Taxation                                                   | "Understanding the emergence, adoption and perceived impacts of corporate tax practices in Australia"                                                                                                 | Mattia Anesa                                       | University of Queensland, Australia |

**Table 1 cont.**

| Appendix | Topic Area                          | Pitch Title                                                                                                                               | Pitcher(s)       | Affiliation                         |
|----------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|-------------------------------------|
| A21      | Banking                             | “Bank Risk Exposure, Bank Failure and Off Balance Sheet Activities: an Empirical Analysis for U.S. Commercial Banks” (reverse engineered) | Hengsheng Nie    | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A22      | Behavioural Finance                 | “Corporate Social Responsibility and CEO Overconfidence”                                                                                  | Sid Song         | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A23      | Public Policy & Regulation          | “Are member needs being better met under MySuper?”                                                                                        | Geoff Warren     | CIFR                                |
| A24      | Education                           | “Developing graduate skills and attributes through internationalisation in Australian Universities”                                       | Jac Birt         | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A25      | Market Microstructure               | “Algorithmic trading in the foreign exchange market”                                                                                      | Dave Michayluk   | University of Technology, Sydney    |
| A26      | Information Systems                 | “The Impact of Leadership in Agile Information System Development Projects”                                                               | Mone Andrias     | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A27      | Immunology                          | “Identification of Novel Immune Cells”                                                                                                    | Marita Smith     | Australian National University      |
| A28      | Biology                             | “Genetic sequencing of Eucalypts”                                                                                                         | Marita Smith     | Australian National University      |
| A29      | Management Accounting               | “The role of heteroglossic dialogue in performance evaluation: a case study of a non-government organization”                             | David Smith      | Monash University                   |
| A30      | Multidisciplinary (climate science) | “Fingerprinting major dust storms: a multidisciplinary approach”                                                                          | Marita Smith     | Australian National University      |
| A31      | Accounting Theory                   | “A General Theory of Accounting”                                                                                                          | Gabriel Donleavy | University of New England           |
| A32      | Accounting History                  | “The gap between just price and fair value”                                                                                               | Gabriel Donleavy | University of New England           |
| A33      | Archaeology                         | “History in their bones”                                                                                                                  | Marita Smith     | Australian National University      |
| A34      | Behavioural Economics               | “The Impact of Home Loan Key Fact Sheets on Borrowers’ Judgments of Loan Suitability”                                                     | Ross Skelton     | Queensland University of Technology |
| A35      | Humour                              | “Mickey Mouse & Climate Change”                                                                                                           | Robert Faff      | University of Queensland, Australia |
| A36      | Phytology                           | “The chemistry of sexual deception in orchids”                                                                                            | Marita Smith     | Australian National University      |
| A37      | Organic Chemistry                   | “Synthesis of fungal metabolites from novel medicinal mushrooms”                                                                          | Marita Smith     | Australian National University      |

Note: all exemplar templates listed in this table are available from the online Internet appendix at: <http://www.business.uq.edu.au/supplementary-material-pitching-research>

**Figure 1: Faff's (2015) Pitching Template**

| Pitcher's Name              |                                                                              | FoR category |  | Date Completed |  |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|--|----------------|--|
| (A) Working Title           |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| (B) Basic Research Question |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| (C) Key paper(s)            |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| (D) Motivation/Puzzle       |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| THREE                       | Three core aspects of any empirical research project i.e. the "IDioTs" guide |              |  |                |  |
| (E) Idea?                   |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| (F) Data?                   |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| (G) Tools?                  |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| TWO                         | Two key questions                                                            |              |  |                |  |
| (H) What's New?             |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| (I) So What?                |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| ONE                         | One bottom line                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| (J) Contribution?           |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |
| (K) Other Considerations    |                                                                              |              |  |                |  |

Source: Faff (2015).

Figure 2: Pitching the “Pitch Research” Project

|                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                     |                  |                       |          |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------|------------------|-----------------------|----------|
| <b>Pitcher's Name</b>              | Robert Faff                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>FoR category</b> | Higher Education | <b>Date Completed</b> | 18/12/14 |
| <b>(A) Working Title</b>           | “Pitching Research”                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(B) Basic Research Question</b> | Create a tool/mindset that captures the essential information needed to give a sound basis for starting a new research project                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(C) Key paper(s)</b>            | Stokes, D., (2013), “Generating Innovative Research Ideas”, Journal of Accounting and Management Information Systems 12, 145-155.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(D) Motivation/Puzzle</b>       | The hardest thing about doing research is starting it. Finishing the research is also difficult, but unless you begin, finishing is irrelevant. Novice researchers rarely know where to start – they often suffer from being overwhelmed. Novice researchers never know what are the essential items of information that would be convincing to their potential research mentor (or supervisor). Everyone is busy – especially supervisors and research mentors. Creating a more effective means to “pitch” a research topic would be beneficial for all concerned.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>THREE</b>                       | <b>Three</b> core aspects of any empirical research project i.e. the “IDioTs” guide                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(E) Idea?</b>                   | Its all about the “pitch”. The relationship between the two parties to the “pitch” is central and critical – hence, I purposefully draw attention to this linkage by choosing the paired terms “pitcher”/“pitchee”. Then, the core idea here is developing a pitch “template” – a succinctly formatted device that is logically designed, builds in its flow and allows a clear and coherent message to be conveyed between the “pitcher” and the “pitchee”                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(F) Data?</b>                   | Normally in research we expect to see “data”. The nature of data in this project is very different. In a sense the data are the worked examples of the template showing novice researchers in a very real and practical way “proof of concept” – how it can work in their field of interest.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(G) Tools?</b>                  | The core tool here is the “naked” pitch template itself. This is supplemented by:<br><b>Short term:</b> • advice on use; • a version of the template with “cues”<br><b>Long term:</b> • evolving library of examples; • expanding set of Internet resources including a Youtube video; appendices; PowerPoint slides and Prezi presentation template; • technology enhanced delivery of template technology via web-based application.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>TWO</b>                         | <b>Two</b> key questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(H) What's New?</b>             | Novelty can be thought of in a few ways. First, focusing attention on the common challenge faced by novice researchers: to initiate a “conversation” [i.e. meaningfully convey essential information] with a mentor in a simple and clear way regarding a new research idea. Second, the novelty is around the simple template device – not new in its constituent parts, but new in its overall design by bringing together cohesively, essential ingredients that create a simple “synergistic” package. The template “tool” is a big driver, but this is inextricably linked to the “idea” as well. The worked examples, as “data”, are also very important for inducing wide takeup of the concept.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(I) So What?</b>                | My pitching template research is important because it will lead to major efficiencies in the research process – efficiencies that can be characterised by substantial savings in time at the beginning of the research journey – for BOTH novice and seasoned researchers (mentors). This saving in time will have positive psychological/motivational effects that help magnify the benefits going forward. These benefits will manifest in: higher quality research outcomes; more timely PhD/paper completions and help create good long-term research habits that will give a “sustainability” dimension.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>ONE</b>                         | <b>One</b> bottom line                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(J) Contribution?</b>           | FREE provision of a simple tool and deep support ... across the full spectrum of academic research ... with many potential applications ... finance, accounting, management, CSR, chemistry, physics, healthcare, psychology ... short-term and long-term benefits to all researchers. Extensive impact on research that is NOT discipline constrained                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                     |                  |                       |          |
| <b>(K) Other Considerations</b>    | No direct Collaboration – but extensive support “collaboration” critical eg provision of examples to populate an expanding library; workshops/seminars/pitch day events<br>Target Journal: ultimately - highest profile/quality education-type journal, relevant to higher education/research.<br>“Risk” assessment: (1) “competitor” risk - low; (2) risk of “obsolescence” – low, involves an issue of enduring concern relevant to ALL research fields; (3) “no result” risk – low.<br>Other challenge(s)? getting people to “listen” and “invest” a little time reading what is being offered – the “salesman” dilemma.<br>Is the scope appropriate? As potential examples expand, exploit the online angle.<br>Perfect template is unattainable – convince audience of core benefit, encourage adaptation to personal preference. Need to confront various negative “syndromes”: (a) “in house” templates/“I already do this!”; (b) Too good to be true; (c) Too simple to be useful; (d) Nothing new, so little value. |                     |                  |                       |          |

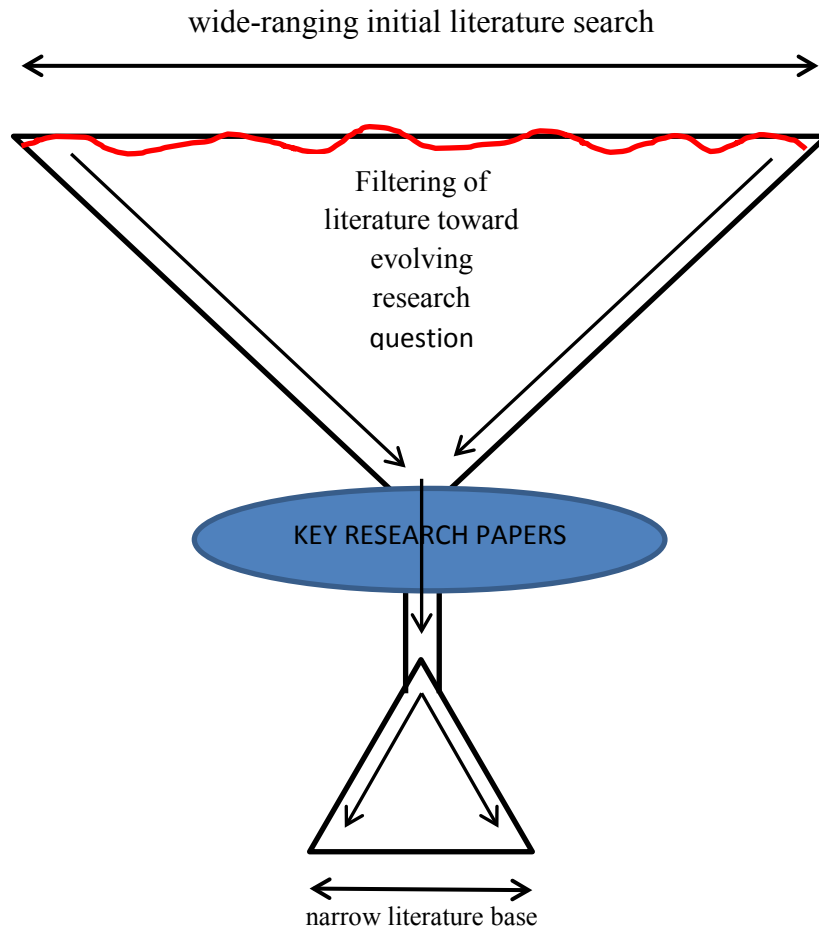
Source: Faff (2015).

Figure 3: Faff's (2015) Pitching Template with Cues for the Pitcher

| Pitcher's Name              | Your name here <sup>71</sup>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | FoR category | Field of research? | Date Completed | Insert date here |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|--------------------|----------------|------------------|
| (A) Working Title           | Succinct/informative title here                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |              |                    |                |                  |
| (B) Basic Research Question | IN one sentence, define the <b>key</b> features of the research question.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |              |                    |                |                  |
| (C) Key paper(s)            | Identify the key paper(s) which most critically underpin the topic (just standard reference details). Ideally one paper, but at most 3 papers. Ideally, by “gurus” in the field, either recently published in Tier 1 journal(s) or recent working paper e.g. on SSRN.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |              |                    |                |                  |
| (D) Motivation/Puzzle       | IN one short paragraph (say a max of 100 words) capture the core motivation – which may include identifying a “puzzle” that you hope to resolve.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |              |                    |                |                  |
| THREE                       | Three core aspects of any empirical research project i.e. the “IDioTs” guide                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |              |                    |                |                  |
| (E) Idea?                   | Identify the “core” idea that drives the intellectual content of this research topic. If possible, articulate the central hypothesis(es). Identify the key dependent (“explained”) variable and the key test/independent (“explanatory”) variable(s). Is there any serious threat from endogeneity here? If so, what is the identification strategy? EG: is there a natural experiment or exogenous shock that can be exploited? Is there any theoretical “tension” that can be exploited?                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |              |                    |                |                  |
| (F) Data?                   | (1) What data do you propose to use? e.g. country/setting; Why? Unit of analysis? Individuals, firms, portfolios, industries, countries ...? sample period; sampling interval? Daily, weekly, monthly, quarterly, annual, ... Type of data: firm specific vs. industry vs. macro vs. ...?<br>(2) What sample size do you expect? Cross-sectionally? In Time-series/longitudinal?<br>(3) Is it a panel dataset?<br>(4) Data Sources? Are the data commercially available? Any hand-collecting required? Are the data to be created based on your own survey instrument? Or by interviews? Timeframe? Research assistance needed? Funding/grants? Are they novel new data?<br>(5) Will there be any problem with missing data/observations? Database merge issues? Data manipulation/“cleansing” issues?<br>(6) Will your “test” variables exhibit adequate (“meaningful”) variation to give good power? Quality/reliability of data?<br>(7) Other data obstacles? E.g. external validity? construct validity? |              |                    |                |                  |
| (G) Tools?                  | Basic empirical framework and research design? Is it a regression model approach? Survey instrument issues/design? Interview design? Econometric software needed/appropriate for job? Accessible through normal channels? Knowledge of implementation of appropriate or best statistical/econometric tests? Compatibility of data with planned empirical framework? Is statistical validity an issue?                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |              |                    |                |                  |
| TWO                         | Two key questions                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |              |                    |                |                  |
| (H) What's New?             | Is the novelty in the idea/data/tools? Which is the “driver”, and are the “passengers” likely to pull their weight? Is this “Mickey Mouse” [i.e. can you draw a simple Venn diagram to depict the novelty in your proposal?]                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |              |                    |                |                  |
| (I) So What?                | Why is it important to know the answer? How will major decisions/behaviour/activity etc be influenced by the outcome of this research?                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |              |                    |                |                  |
| ONE                         | One bottom line                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |              |                    |                |                  |
| (J) Contribution?           | What is the primary source of the contribution to the relevant research literature?                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |              |                    |                |                  |
| (K) Other Considerations    | Is <b>Collaboration</b> needed/desirable? – idea/data/tools? (either internal or external to your institution)<br><b>Target</b> Journal(s)? Realistic? Sufficiently ambitious?<br><b>“Risk”</b> assessment [“low” vs. “moderate” vs. “high”: “no result” risk; “competitor” risk (ie being beaten by a competitor); risk of “obsolescence”; other risks?<br>Are there any serious challenge(s) that you face in executing this plan? What are they? Are they related to the Idea? The Data? The Tools? Are there ethical considerations? Ethics clearance?<br>Is the <b>scope</b> appropriate? Not too narrow, not too broad.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |              |                    |                |                  |

Source: Faff (2015).

<sup>71</sup> The guidelines in red should be deleted and replaced by the best available “answers” in relation to the proposed research topic, obeying an overall 2-page (1,000 word) limit.

**Figure 4: Faff's (2015) Cocktail Glass Approach to Reading/Filtering the Literature**

Source: Faff (2015).

**Figure 5: A Generic Characterisation of how Mickey Mouse might help to identify Novelty in Research**

